



Health & Wellness Hub — Sensory-Friendly Meal Planner (12-Week)

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Important Note (Read First)

This workbook is for educational purposes only. It is not medical advice and does not replace guidance from your healthcare provider. Every child's needs, preferences, and challenges are unique. Before making any significant changes to your family's mealtime routines, recipes, or dietary practices, please consult with your doctor, registered dietitian, or relevant therapists.

Remember: Collaboration with your healthcare team leads to the best progress and ensures safety, especially when managing allergies or complex medical histories. This planner aims to give you calm, reliable tools—but always put your family's individual needs and comfort first.

- This planner is informational. Consult professionals for medical, dietary, or behavioral concerns.
- Use all recipes and tips as a starting point, not as a strict prescription.
- Adapt ideas to meet your child's sensory profile, comfort, and needs.
- You're the expert on your child—your observations and instincts matter most.
- Progress happens in partnership: Your input, your child's voice, plus professional guidance creates the safest path forward.





There's no one-size-fits-all approach to nutrition for autistic children. Sometimes, the smallest changes make the biggest difference.

Feeding Matters

Program Promise: What You'll Find Inside



Low-Pressure Approach

No meal battles. Tips are designed to support gradual, stress-free exposure without pressure or guilt.



Family Flexibility

Adapts to your household routines, needs, and preferences—built for real life, not perfection.



Multiple Ways to Succeed

Weekly choice points and recipe swaps support both food explorers and selective eaters. Progress, not perfection.



Safety & Support

Allergy-friendly, sensory-informed recipes and routines make safety and comfort a top priority.

How to Use This Planner

Welcome! To make the most of the Sensory-Friendly Meal Planner, follow these five friendly guidelines. Each is designed to support your family's unique journey toward enjoyable, nutritious meals—at your pace.

- Start Slow: Introduce new foods and sensory activities one at a time. Baby steps are wins!
- Pick Your Priorities: Choose two weekly goals—don't aim for everything, every week.
- Use the Trackers: Make note of your child's responses, triggers, and successes. Reflection makes progress visible.
- Recipe Your Way: Food swaps and bridge options are encouraged for any sensory or allergy reason.
- Celebrate Small Progress: Improvement is personal. Every taste, sniff, or touch is progress—no judgment.
- ☒ Print or save a week at a time.
- ☒ Use the checkboxes and trackers to mark wins—even non-food ones.
- ☒ Save space for your notes and stories.
- ☒ Invite your child's input (verbally, with stickers, or by picking foods).
- ☒ Ask for support from your care team as you go.

5 Keys to Success



Start At Their Level

Honor your child's baseline. Use familiar foods as the anchor for each meal plan and build from there!



Use Checklists and Trackers

Track comfort, triggers, and wins (including non-food milestones). This makes progress visible for you and your child.



Bridge Foods Build Skills

Bridge foods help connect favorites to new foods. Small steps keep meals non-threatening.

The Sensory Ladder: 7 Steps to Exploring New Foods

Sensory food experience has many layers—just like taste itself. Use this ladder to guide gentle exploration at your child's comfort level. Progress might pause or jump. All rungs count! Use one or several ladders each week based on your child's needs.

1. Step 1: Looks at the new food (visual)
2. Step 2: Touches the food with hands (texture/touch)
3. Step 3: Brings food near nose (smell)
4. Step 4: Touches lips/tongue to food (tactile/taste preview)
5. Step 5: Holds food in mouth or licks (exploratory taste)
6. Step 6: Bites/chews and spits out (taste + oral input)
7. Step 7: Eats and swallows (sensory acceptance!)



Quick Sensory Ladder Tips



Visual Curiosity Counts

Seeing new foods (even from a distance) builds comfort. No pressure to touch or taste right away.



Smell is a Sensory Step

Inviting your child to smell, but not taste, can expand food acceptance gradually.



Touch is Progress

Allowing mess and touch encourages exploration—even if the food isn't eaten that day.

Allergy-Friendly System: Safety First Labels

All recipes in this planner are designed so you can swap key ingredients to fit the following dietary needs. Each recipe lists which codes apply. Look for these handy labels:

DF: Dairy-Free

EF: Egg-Free

GF: Gluten-Free

NF: Nut-Free

SF: Soy-Free

Always check labels and individual product ingredients for cross-contamination or manufacturing changes. Allergen information is a starting point—your family's health and safety decisions are most important.

Research-Informed Principles (Plain English)

- **Exposure, Not Pressure:** Children need repeated, low-pressure exposure to feel safe with new foods. Gentle, non-judgmental experiences work best.
- **Food Chaining:** Linking familiar foods to new ones using similarities builds confidence. Bridge foods help connect "safe" and "target" items.
- **Predictable Routines:** Consistent meal and snack times help children prepare for food experiences. Routines lower anxiety for everyone.
- **Caregiver Support:** Your own comfort and well-being set the tone. Use energy-saver tips and take breaks as needed.
- **Trusted Resources:** Principles reflect guidance from recognized organizations, including Autism Speaks, Feeding Matters, and dietitians focused on neurodiversity-affirming feeding practices.

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**Progress is measured in comfort, not just bites.
Every food relationship has its own pace.**

Autism Speaks

Weekly Tools: Setting Up for Success

Each week's section includes everything you need to structure meals, track your child's sensory preferences, and set (realistic) goals to celebrate progress. Use these tools again and again. Adjust to your family's routines!

Sensory Food Profile Table

Food	Color	Texture	Smell	Temperature	Sound (Crunch/Soft)

Weekly Goals: Choose Two

 goal progress icon

Try One New Food

Pick a small, manageable new food to explore visually, by smell, touch, or taste.



Add to Meal Routine

Select one mealtime to keep consistent, supporting predictable days.



Share Successes with Others

Tell your care provider or family about small wins, big or little!

No-Pressure Scripts (Try These!)

- You don't have to taste it—just look is great.
- It's okay to say no today. Maybe next time.
- You can help pick what we make tonight!
- I wonder what this food sounds like when we crunch it.
- Want to touch with a fork or spoon first?

Use these calm words to support curiosity and connection, not battles. Over time, children's comfort grows when there's no pressure and plenty of support.



Caregiver Energy Saver (Callout)



Prep Ahead When You Can

Batch-prepping veggies or safe foods (even once a week) can lighten weekday stress and keep calm at meal times.



Breaks Are Okay Too

Not every day is a food explorer day. Celebrate connection, not just new bites.

Weekly Structure Overview: Weeks 1–12

Each week at a glance: Focus on two sensory goals, follow the meal structure, choose safe anchors for each meal, and use bridges to expand gently. Adapt freely for your child's pace and preferences. Every week features fresh opportunities—use what works, skip what doesn't!

A photograph of wooden blocks arranged to spell out the words 'NEXT' and 'WEEK' on a light blue surface. The word 'NEXT' is formed by four blocks in the top row, and 'WEEK' is formed by four blocks in the bottom row.

N E X T
W E E K

Sample 7-Day Meal Plan Table

Day	Meal	Safe Anchor	Optional Exposure	Bridge Food
Monday	Breakfast	Plain toast	Jam (smell/touch)	Sunflower seed butter
Monday	Lunch	Pasta with olive oil	Broccoli (just on plate)	Parmesan sprinkle
Monday	Snack	Apple slices	Yogurt dip (smell only)	GF granola
Monday	Dinner	Chicken nuggets	Carrot coins	Crispy chickpeas
Tuesday	Breakfast	Oatmeal	Raisins	Chia seeds
Tuesday	Lunch	Turkey roll-up	Cheese slice	Lettuce leaf
Tuesday	Snack	Rice cake	Almond butter	Blueberries
Tuesday	Dinner	Plain rice	Edamame beans (touch only)	Teriyaki tofu

Recipe: Quick Veggie Pasta (GF/DF/NF)

Why it works (sensory): Soft, familiar texture with optional color variety (carrots/zucchini), simple sauce, and room for bridge toppings.

- 8 oz gluten-free pasta
- 1 cup shredded carrots/zucchini
- 1/4 cup olive oil or safe butter alternative
- Salt (to taste)

1. Cook pasta as directed.
2. Sauté veggies in olive oil until soft.
3. Toss pasta and veggies together. Add salt.
4. Try adding one bridge: sprinkle of dairy-free cheese, or a hint of tomato sauce.

Allergy swaps: Use egg-free pasta and nut-free toppings as needed. Bridge option: add half a cherry tomato on the side.

Recipe: Fruity Breakfast Quesadillas (GF/DF/EF/NF)

Why it works (sensory): Crunchy warm tortilla, familiar fruit, optional new spread as bridge.

- 2 GF tortillas
- 1/2 cup sliced strawberries or apples
- 1 T sunflower seed butter or safe spread
- Cinnamon (optional)

1. Spread sunflower butter on tortilla.
2. Layer with fruit. Sprinkle cinnamon if using.
3. Top with 2nd tortilla. Warm in pan until crisp.
4. Cut into wedges. Offer a small bowl of yogurt dip as bridge.

Allergy swaps: Use soy-free spread if needed. Bridge option: a single slice with new fruit or a drizzle of honey.

Recipe: Colorful Sticks Snack Tray (GF/DF/EF/NF/SF)

Why it works (sensory): Visual variety, easy finger foods, and a dip as a safe way to try something new.

- Carrot and cucumber sticks
- Red bell pepper strips
- GF pretzel rods
- Favorite dip: hummus, safe yogurt, or guacamole

1. Arrange sticks by color on tray.
2. Add small bowls of dip. Invite touch or smell first.
3. Encourage dipping or just exploring with fingers.

Allergy swaps: Pick dip to match your codes. Bridge option: one new veggie stick per snack.

Recipe: Simple Chicken Rice Bowls (GF/DF/EF/NF/SF)

Why it works (sensory): Build-your-own style makes control possible, soft textures, and mix-or-not option.

- 2 cups cooked rice (white or brown)
 - 1 cup cooked diced chicken
 - 1/2 cup steamed peas or carrots
 - 1 T olive oil or safe sauce
1. Place rice, chicken, and veggies in separate sections of bowl.
 2. Drizzle olive oil or add safe sauce. Top with optional bridge: a squeeze of lemon or sprinkle of sesame seeds.
 3. Mix or eat separately, as desired.

Allergy swaps: Use plant-based protein if vegetarian. No sesame for sesame allergies. Bridge option: try a tiny portion of sauce or a mix of two foods.

Recipe: Quick Banana Oat Cookies (GF/DF/EF/NF/SF)

Why it works (sensory): Soft texture, mild flavor, simple two-step process. Add-ins are the bridge.

- 2 ripe bananas, mashed
 - 1 cup quick oats (certified GF)
 - Optional: cinnamon, shredded coconut, or chocolate chips
1. Mix bananas and oats. Stir in optional add-ins.
 2. Scoop onto lined tray; bake at 350°F/175°C for 10–12 min.
 3. Cool and serve, with bridge: add a single new sprinkle or spice for exposure.

Allergy swaps: Top 8 free. Bridge option: one cookie with coconut or spice, the rest plain.

Food Chaining Map Table

Safe Food	Bridge Food	Target Food
Plain pasta	Pasta with olive oil	Pasta with veggie sauce
Plain bread	Toast with jam	Whole grain toast
Chicken nuggets	Chicken with crunchy crumb	Grilled chicken
Apple slices	Apple with yogurt dip	Pear slices
Rice	Rice with beans	Quinoa mix

Printable Trackers: Daily Exposure & Triggers

Use these grids every week to build awareness and keep stress low. Color in boxes, add stickers, or jot notes each day. Include triggers, supports that worked, and tiny wins—every step is important.

Day	Food/Experience	Sensory Ladder Step	Child's Response	Caregiver Notes
Monday				
Tuesday				
Wednesday				
Thursday				
Friday				
Saturday				
Sunday				

Date	Trigger/Event	Support Used	Outcome/Notes

Red Flags: When to Seek Professional Support

If you notice any of these, pause the food exposures and contact your healthcare team or a feeding specialist:

- Weight loss, poor growth, or dehydration
- Persistent vomiting or food refusal
- Choking, gagging, or swallowing problems
- Food or liquid comes up through the nose or airway
- Signs of severe allergy (hives, difficulty breathing, swelling)
- Meal-related meltdowns with distress lasting hours
- Mealtime appears to cause pain or distress beyond typical pickiness

Conclusion: Celebrate Every Step

Thank you for using the Health & Wellness Hub Sensory-Friendly Meal Planner! By showing up, observing, and honoring each child's sensory cues, you are doing brave, beautiful work. Share successes, keep adapting, and don't hesitate to ask your healthcare team for partnership along the way. Small steps, big difference.

Planner designed for educational use—consult your health professionals before making changes. You are not alone on this path. Here's to joyful, low-pressure meals for the whole family!

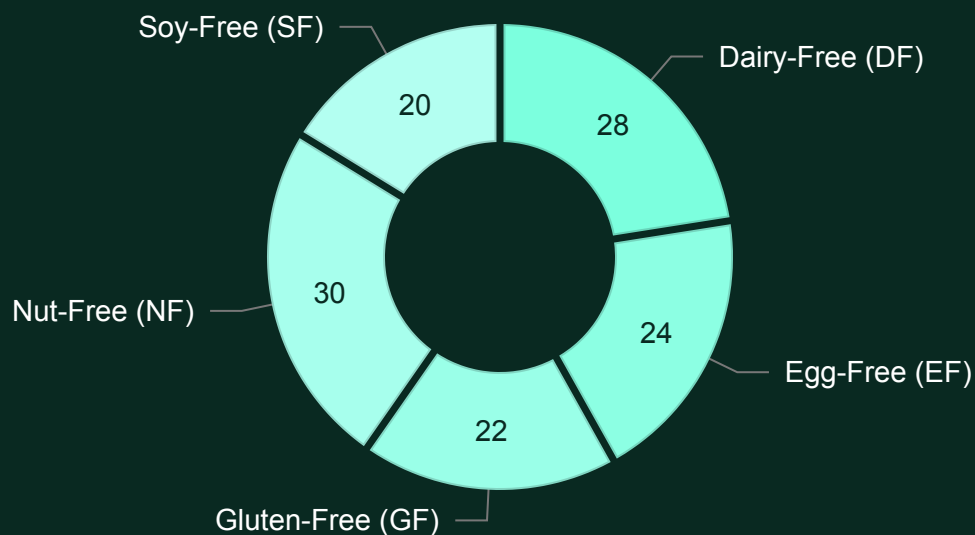
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The journey to
acceptance begins
with understanding,
not with a bite.

— Anonymous

Allergy Labels Chart (Quick Reference)

Common Allergy-Free Recipe Coverage



Most recipes in this planner are nut-free and dairy-free, with a strong focus on other allergy-friendly adaptations. Adjust according to your child's diagnosed allergies.